

Joshua Rasmussen's "How Reason Can Lead to God" Through the Lens of TNA: Necessary Foundation as Admissibility Structure

Author: Claudio Bresciano

Abstract

Joshua Rasmussen's *How Reason Can Lead to God* develops a contemporary rationalist argument for the existence of a necessary foundation underlying contingent reality. Starting from the existence of dependent entities, Rasmussen argues that the totality of contingent things cannot explain itself and therefore requires an independent and unlimited ground. This paper reinterprets Rasmussen's argument through the framework of the **Theory of Axiomatic Necessity (TNA)**. We argue that Rasmussen's "necessary foundation" can be understood as a particular manifestation of the TNA distinction between the operational domain (N_o) and the admissibility domain (N_i). While Rasmussen frames the issue in terms of contingency and necessity, TNA reformulates it as a problem of **Failure of Local Closure**: a system cannot fully derive the conditions that legitimate its own existence, interpretation, or rule space from within itself. The paper identifies points of convergence and divergence between Rasmussen's metaphysical project and TNA, showing that both approaches confront the same structural boundary from different directions.

1. Introduction

Throughout the history of philosophy, one recurring question appears in different forms:

Why is there something rather than nothing?

Classical metaphysics typically approaches this question through causal chains, substance theories, or arguments from contingency. In *How Reason Can Lead to God* (2019), philosopher Joshua Rasmussen presents a modern version of the argument from contingency, seeking to establish the existence of a necessary and unlimited foundation underlying reality.

Rasmussen's project differs from traditional theological arguments in its emphasis on logical structure rather than religious authority. His central claim is that the existence of dependent entities ultimately points toward a reality that is independent and necessary.

This paper argues that Rasmussen's argument can be reformulated within the conceptual framework of the **Theory of Axiomatic Necessity (TNA)**. In particular, we show that Rasmussen's necessary foundation corresponds structurally to what TNA identifies as N_1 , the domain of admissibility conditions external to operational systems.

2. Rasmussen's Argument from Contingency

Rasmussen begins with an apparently simple observation:

Many things appear dependent.

Examples include:

- Human beings.
- Stars.
- Biological organisms.
- Physical systems.
- Entire universes.

These entities could have been different or might not have existed at all.

Let:

$$D = \{d_1, d_2, d_3, \dots\}$$

represent the set of dependent entities.

Rasmussen then asks:

What explains the existence of the totality of dependent things?

If every member of D depends on something else, then the collection itself appears dependent.

The explanatory chain therefore seems incomplete.

The central intuition is that an entirely dependent reality lacks sufficient explanatory closure.

Consequently, Rasmussen concludes that there must exist a reality that is:

- Independent.
- Necessary.
- Unlimited.
- Not itself dependent upon anything else.

He refers to this reality as the **Foundation**.

3. The TNA Reformulation

TNA distinguishes between two structural domains:

DOMAIN	DEFINITION	FUNCTION
N_0	Operational domain	Generates states, processes, and trajectories
N_1	Admissibility domain	Selects and legitimizes realizable structures

Within this framework, Rasmussen's contingent reality corresponds naturally to N_0 .

N_0 contains:

- Physical events.
- Causal chains.
- Logical derivations.
- Operational systems.
- All structures governed by dependency relations.

The Foundation sought by Rasmussen occupies a structurally different role.

Rather than being another element inside the dependent system, it functions as the condition that allows the dependent system to exist as a coherent domain.

From the perspective of TNA:

$$Foundation \approx N_1$$

4. The Problem of Global Closure

The crucial step in Rasmussen's argument concerns the totality of contingent reality.

Suppose we define:

$$T = \{all\ dependent\ entities\}$$

The question becomes:

What explains T ?

If the explanation lies inside T , then the explanation itself belongs to the dependent domain.

The explanatory chain remains internal.

But if every explanation remains internal, the system appears unable to account for its own existence as a whole.

This is precisely the structure identified by TNA as **Failure of Local Closure**.

5. Failure of Local Closure

TNA formalizes the principle:

No operational system can fully generate the conditions that legitimize its own admissibility.

Applied to Rasmussen's argument:

- Dependent entities belong to N_0 .
- Their explanatory relations belong to N_0 .
- The totality of those relations remains within N_0 .

The problem is that the legitimacy of N_0 itself remains unexplained.

Symbolically:

$$N_0 \not\Rightarrow N_0$$

in the sense that N_0 cannot completely ground its own admissibility.

An external selector is required.

TNA therefore predicts the same structural necessity Rasmussen discovers through contingency reasoning.

6. The Regress Problem

Suppose the foundation itself were merely another dependent entity.

Then it would require its own explanation.

Let:

$$F_1$$

be the proposed foundation.

If:

$$F_1 \in N_0$$

then:

$$F_1 \rightarrow F_2$$

and:

$$F_2 \rightarrow F_3$$

leading to:

$$F_1 \leftarrow F_2 \leftarrow F_3 \leftarrow \dots$$

This produces an infinite regress.

Rasmussen interprets this regress as evidence for a necessary being.

TNA interprets it as evidence for the impossibility of complete closure within N_0 .

The conclusions differ metaphysically but share the same structural diagnosis.

7. Foundation versus Admissibility

Despite their similarities, Rasmussen and TNA diverge on a critical point.

Rasmussen's conclusion is ontological.

The Foundation is understood as something that exists necessarily.

TNA remains agnostic about the ontological status of N_1 .

For TNA:

N_1 is defined functionally.

It is the structure that:

- Selects admissibility.
- Enables realization.
- Prevents infinite regress.
- Allows operational domains to stabilize.

Therefore:

$$N_1$$

is not necessarily a substance, object, or entity.

It is a structural necessity.

This distinction separates TNA from both classical theism and traditional metaphysics.

8. The Persistent Search for "Something"

One of the most striking implications of Rasmussen's work concerns a pattern that appears throughout philosophy.

Whenever explanatory chains reach their limit, philosophers tend to search for some ultimate "something."

Historically this "something" has taken many forms:

- Plato's Forms.
- Aristotle's Substance.
- Leibniz's Necessary Being.
- Kant's Noumenon.
- Wittgenstein's State of Affairs.
- Rasmussen's Foundation.

TNA suggests a different interpretation.

The recurring appearance of a "something" is not necessarily evidence for a particular metaphysical object.

Rather, it may reflect the structural inability of No systems to generate their own admissibility conditions.

The search for a foundation becomes the philosophical manifestation of Failure of Local Closure.

9. Beyond Existence: Meaning and Consciousness

Rasmussen's argument primarily concerns existence.

TNA extends the same structural principle into additional domains.

The same pattern appears in:

- Rule-following.
- Semantics.
- Interpretation.
- Consciousness.
- Artificial intelligence.

For example:

The operational description of a brain may specify neural activity.

Yet it does not automatically determine meaning.

Similarly:

The operational description of a computer may specify state transitions.

Yet it does not determine whether the system is performing addition or Kripke's quaddition.

In each case:

$$N_0$$

fails to fully determine admissibility.

The same structural gap reappears.

10. Conclusion

Joshua Rasmussen's *How Reason Can Lead to God* and the Theory of Axiomatic Necessity approach reality from different philosophical traditions but converge on a common structural insight.

Rasmussen argues that dependent reality cannot ultimately explain itself and therefore requires an independent foundation.

TNA reformulates this insight as a manifestation of Failure of Local Closure.

Within TNA:

- Dependent reality corresponds to N_0 .
- The necessary foundation corresponds structurally to N_1 .
- Infinite explanatory regress signals the inability of N_0 to generate its own admissibility conditions.

The principal difference lies in interpretation.

Rasmussen identifies the foundation with a necessary and unlimited reality.

TNA identifies a structural necessity for admissibility without committing to a specific metaphysical ontology.

Viewed through this lens, Rasmussen's argument becomes not merely an argument for God but a powerful illustration of a more general principle:

No operational domain can fully derive the legitimacy of its own existence, interpretation, or rule space from within itself.

The necessity Rasmussen discovers may therefore be understood as a special case of a broader structural boundary—one that appears wherever systems attempt to explain themselves entirely from within their own domain.

References

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